Exploring Linguistic Simplification in Parliaments

Bocconi University Department of Social and Political Science

Filippo Panfoli 3158433

filippo.panfoli@studbocconi.it | PanfoliF |

0009-0000-7861-8036 | https://github.com/PanfoliF

Replication materials / LaTeX sources: PanfoliF/thesis

Version: v1.1 | **Last updated:** October 11, 2026

Keywords:

JEL:

Prepared for: , taught by Prof. Garmain Gauthier

October 11, 2026

Abstract

This study assesses the impact of the introduction of television broadcasting in the House of Commons. The following pages describe the impact of this reform on the language used by the Members of the House. Literature has already studied the effects and consequesces of similar reforms on the language on other Parliaments. However, the case of the House of Commons is of particular interest because it is both the most ancient democratic parliament and on of the last to have adopted television broadcasting. In order to eclude the influence of cuncurrent variables and events the study follows a difference in difference design. The language used by members of the House of Lords is the control group. In fact, this house is not elected and well mimics all other relevant features of the House of Commons.

Contents

I Introduction **1**

1 Literature Rreview **1**

2 General Background on the UK Political System and UK Parliament **2**

3 Seminal contributions to the study of parliaments through text as data techniques **2**

3.1 Bipolarity and Stability 6

3.2 History and Neorealist Empirical Claims 6

4 The Power Transition **7**

4.1 Dissatisfaction, the Status Quo, and War 7

5 Cranmer and Desmarais, 2017 **10**

5.1 The Levels-of-Analysis Framework 10

5.2 Systemic-Level Theories 10

5.3 Social-Level Theories 12

5.4 Individual-Level Theories 12

5.5 General Trends 13

6 One World Rival Theories **13**

6.1 The Divided House of Liberalism 14

6.2 Idealism 15

7 Why "isms" Are Evil David Lake **16**

7.1 Central Argument and Purpose 16

7.2 Theory: How Research Traditions Become Academic Sects 16

7.3 The first pathology: reifying research traditions 16

7.4 The second pathology: reification of canonical works and rewarding extremism . 17

7.5 The third pathology: confusing traditions with theories 17

7.6 The fourth pathology: selective empirical focus 17

7.7 The fifth pathology: the search for intellectual hegemony 17

7.8 Lake's Alternative: Problems, Partial Theories, and a Common Lexicon 17

7.9 Interests, interactions, and institutions 18

7.10 Epistemology: The Enduring Divide 18

7.11 The nomological approach 18

7.12 The narrative approach 18

7.13 Epistemological Sectarianism and Lake's Recommendations 18
7.14 Conclusion 19

8 Challenges to the Liberal Order: Summary **19**
8.1 Introduction and Central Argument 19
8.2 Order 19
8.3 International and the Westphalian Order 19
8.4 Liberal: Political Liberalism 20
8.5 Economic Liberalism and Embedded Liberalism 20
8.6 Liberal Internationalism 21
8.7 Universalism and Selective Participation 21
8.8 Challenges from Within the Liberal Core 21
8.9 Nationalist Populism and Political Realignment 21
8.10 External Challengers 22
8.11 The Erosion of Multilateral Institutions 22
8.12 Sources of Resilience 22
8.13 Four Analytic Blind Spots in IR Scholarship 23
8.14 USA and the Future of LIO 23

II Text as Data **24**

9 Semantic Role Labeling **24**
9.1 Selectorate Theory 24
9.2 Public and Private Goods: Who Gets Rewarded as W and S Change? 25

Part I
Introduction

1 Literature Rreview

The literature review will be organised as follows: The first part explores the study of parliaments through scientific lens. The second part introduces the seminal contributions to the study of parliaments through text as data techniques. The third part of the literature review narrows down the framework of analysis. It summarises the scientific studies conducted specifically on the introduction of television broadcasting in the house of commons. The reader will notice that only qualitative studies have been conducted so far.

2 General Background on the UK Political System and UK Parliament

3 Seminal contributions to the study of parliaments through text as data techniques

Bipolar system

- Dominated by **two major powers**.
- Alliances and commitments are clearer.
- Neorealists argue that it creates **less uncertainty** and therefore **more stability**.

Bipolarity is thought to alleviate two of the conditions we have discussed that are thought to increase the risk of war: uncertainty and commitment problems.

Multipolar system

- Contains **more than two major powers**.
- Alliances and third-party reactions are harder to predict.
- Traditionally associated with **greater uncertainty** and instability.

3.0.1 Historical Examples an justificaiton for Neorealism

World War I

- Multipolar Europe had several major powers.
- Alliances and commitments were uncertain.
- Britain's and Italy's behavior was not fully predictable.
- This uncertainty supposedly contributed to instability.

Cold War

- Two clear blocs:
  - **US/NATO**
  - **USSR/Warsaw Pact**
- Commitments were much clearer.
- Used as evidence that bipolar systems involve less uncertainty.

3.0.2 Problem with the Uncertainty Argument

The fact that multipolarity creates more uncertainty does **not automatically mean** that it creates instability.

Uncertainty may:

- make states more **cautious**;
- make some states more **risk-acceptant**;
- have different effects depending on decision makers.

Deutsch and Singer even argue that:

multipolarity may be more stable precisely because it produces uncertainty.

$$Therefore: \ Uncertainty \not\Rightarrow Instability$$

3.0.3 Problem for Neorealist Assumptions

The claim that bipolarity increases stability is **not logically derived from neorealism's basic assumptions**.

If leaders react differently to uncertainty:

- this conflicts with the **unitary rational actor assumption**;
- structural conditions would no longer produce similar state behavior;
- polarity would not have a predictable effect on stability.

3.0.4 Bipolar Balance of Power

Implication: Strict neorealist logic suggests that bipolar stability requires **near-perfect equality of power**.

In a multipolar system, stability depends on **blocking coalitions**.

A coalition controlling half the system's resources can prevent another coalition from becoming dominant.

Perhaps the most common claim among neorealist theorists is that war occurs only when both sides believe that their chance of winning is greater than 50 percent. This is a partial statement of what has come to be known as the balance-of-power theory. It invokes the idea that war is the product of mutual optimism by rival states, meaning that they overestimate their chances of victory

If the neorealist hypothesis were correct, we should observe no wars initiated by the weaker side. The evidence fails to support the hypothesis.

3.0.5 Essential vs. Inessential States

Essential State A state is essential if it is needed to form at least one:

- **blocking coalition**

- **winning coalition**

Other states have an incentive to protect it.

Inessential state A state is inessential if coalitions can succeed without it.
Such a state becomes:

- expendable;
- vulnerable to elimination.

3.0.6 Example of a Stable Multipolar System

Even weak state E is essential to some blocking coalitions.
Therefore:

- other states have incentives to protect E;
- all states remain strategically relevant;
- the system can be **stable**.

3.0.7 Example of an Unstable Multipolar System

Coalitions can win without E.
Therefore:

- E is **inessential**;
- E can be eliminated without threatening the security of the others;
- the system is **unstable**.

3.0.8 Main Implication for Multipolarity

Multipolar systems can be stable under **many different distributions of power**.
Exact equality is not always required.
By contrast, bipolar systems may require a much more precise balance.

Result

> Neorealist assumptions may actually allow **more stable power distributions in multipolar systems than in bipolar systems**.

3.0.9 Historical Record of Essential and Inessential States

Inessential states are states that are unable to turn even one losing alliance into a winning or blocking coalition.

1. Essential states never become inessential.
2. Essential states are never eliminated from the international system.
3. Inessential states never become essential states.
4. Inessential states are always eliminated from the international system.

Each of these propositions is historically false.

3.0.10 Bipolarity and Stability: War

A possible objection is that war is uncertain.

Even if one state is stronger, it may avoid attacking because victory is not guaranteed.

Let:

$$p = \text{probability of victory}$$

A attacks when:

$$p > U_{status\ quo}$$

assuming:

$$U_{winning} = 1, \qquad U_{losing} = 0$$

War depends not only on power, but also on:

- expectations;
- risk;
- satisfaction with the status quo.

Why This Contradicts Neorealism:

This model assumes states can make a: $\Rightarrow$ **trade-off between security and power**

But according to Kenneth Waltz: $\Rightarrow$ **security is the highest end.**

States seek power mainly as a **means to security**, not as an end in itself.

Allowing states to risk survival for possible gains in power therefore conflicts with core neorealist assumptions.

3.0.11 Overall Conclusion

The traditional claim: *Bipolarity* → *Stability* has several problems:

- **uncertainty does not necessarily cause instability**;
- leaders may react differently to uncertainty;
- strict neorealist logic can make bipolar systems stable only under very narrow power distributions;
- multipolar systems can remain stable through **blocking coalitions**;
- introducing probabilistic risk-taking creates assumptions that contradict neorealism itself.

Central conclusion

> **The hypothesis that bipolar systems are more stable than multipolar systems does not logically follow from neorealism's own assumptions.**

3.1 Bipolarity and Stability

1. First, variation in the response to uncertainty violates the unitary rational actor assumption, which contends that important choices in international politics are driven by structural factors, not by considerations internal to the state.
2. Second, if different decision makers respond to uncertainty in different ways, then there is no reason to expect any empirical relationship between bipolarity and stability at all.
3. Third, if leaders differ in how they respond to uncertainty, then the third hypothesis (that states mimic one another) does not hold up.
4. Starting from the neorealist assumptions, we can show that it is logically true that more distributions of power are stable in a multipolar world than in a bipolar world.

3.2 History and Neorealist Empirical Claims

1. The international system was multipolar in structure from 1648 until the defeat of Germany in 1945. Thus, between 1648 and 1945 there were many major powers with no one or two predominating. ⇒ The bipolar system began in 1945 and lasted until about 1989.
2. Using Jack Levy's (1983) classification of great powers since 1492, we can determine whether the longevity of the bipolar system was comparatively long or short. ⇒
3. Another way to evaluate the stability of the international system is to examine the frequency of wars among the most influential states in the world
4. The UN Security Council (UNSC), then, by institutionalizing a multipolar decision-making structure, has provided a counterweight to bipolarity. This too may be an explanation for the long peace.
5. The average interval between general wars is thirty-four years; the longest interval is ninety-nine years, much longer than the so-called long peace. It appears, then, that the bipolar, long peace cannot be considered unusually long after all and that bipolarity is not a superior treatment for the disease of major power war than is multipolarity.

4 The Power Transition

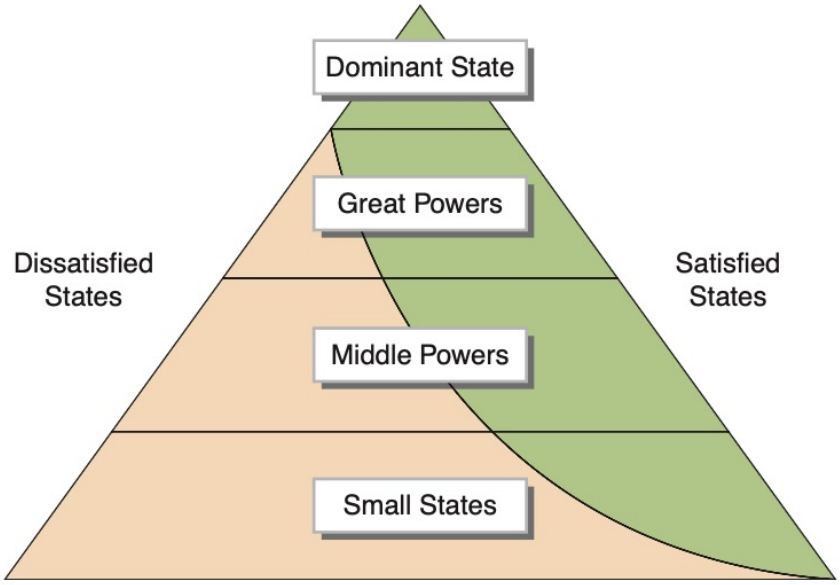
Building on the work of Edward Carr (1939, 1945) and Organski (1958) constructed what was perhaps the first challenge to realism that was neither idealistic nor normative.

- The international system is not anarchic.
- There is only one dominant state at any given time.
- Rather than wishing to maximize security or power, nations are interested in maximizing their **control over the rules and customs that govern international interactions** so that they can define the status quo according to their interests.

Bretton Woods Agreement ⇒ These agreements still maintain a rule-based and normative influence on the trading practices of their members.

Dissatisfaction ⇒ it is the more powerful dissatisfied states that represent the biggest threat to international peace and stability.

FIGURE 5.5 **The Power Transition Power Triangle**



Power transition theory divides the world into two coalitions: (1) satisfied states and (2) dissatisfied states. The stronger a state is, the more likely that it is satisfied with the organization of the international system and the status quo that reflects that system's rules. Weaker states are more likely to be dissatisfied.

Source: Organski (1958).

Figura 1

4.1 Dissatisfaction, the Status Quo, and War

Conflict arises when a dissatisfied state grows strong enough to challenge the authority of the hegemon. Because such a challenge concerns the very way in which international affairs are conducted, the ensuing conflict is fierce and costly.

This time period during which the challenger roughly comes to equal and then surpass the dominant state in power is known as the power transition. It is the time when the threat of a major war is hypothesized to be at its peak. **Contrary to the balance-of-power perspective**, power transition and hegemonic stability theorists believe that major wars are most likely to occur when the power of the opposed states is about equal.

According to these theorists, a balance of power promotes war. They maintain that system-transforming wars—that is, wars that lead to a new power hierarchy and to new rules and norms—will occur only when the power of a challenger and the dominant state are about equal and the power of the challenger is increasing faster than that of the dominant state. These claims have been extended and shown to have **empirical strength** at the regional as well as the global level, so that regional hegemons apparently face the same pressures and the same sources of war as their global counterparts.

Threatening balance of power emerges as a result of differing rates of internal growth between a dominant state and a challenger state. These theories still give little attention to domestic politics per se, but they do recognize that internal factors shape rates of growth.

Power transition theory leads to the hypothesis that system-transforming, high-cost wars are especially likely when a dissatisfied challenger state achieves approximate power parity with the dominant, status quo-defending state.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the distribution of power at which the rivals will fight depends on their willingness to take the risks of waiting. The longer the challenger waits to attack, the higher is its probability of victory. This is true because the challenger's power is growing faster than the dominant state's power. Thus, the longer the challenger puts off a war, the greater will be the odds in its favor. However, the longer it waits, the longer it must endure the rules of international intercourse with which it is dissatisfied.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the interval during which the challenger is willing to fight expands as the expected costs of the war increase, as the challenger's dissatisfaction with the status quo increases, as the challenger's relative growth rate declines, and as the challenger becomes more risk acceptant.

How long the challenger and the dominant states will wait before fighting depends on their respective responses to risk, their relative rates of growth, the expected costs of the war, and their respective degrees of satisfaction with the status quo.

Differences in growth rates turn out not to be crucial empirically.

Power transitions per se cannot explain especially costly wars.

FIGURE 5.6 **Power Transition Theory and the Likelihood of War**

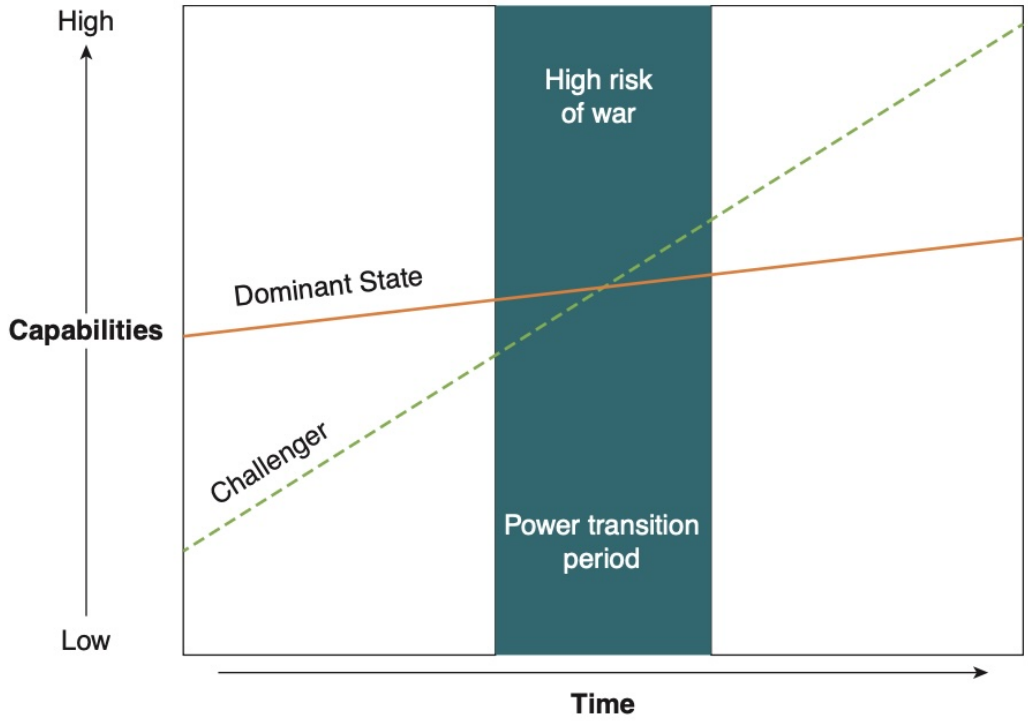


Figura 2

5 Cranmer and Desmarais, 2017

This makes it hard to argue that human nature and related factors are causes of war. The point is that these factors are constants and cannot explain the variations in war and peace over time and space (Waltz 1959, Cashman 1993).

Why does war occur at some times rather than other times, between some states rather than other states, under some political leaders rather than others, in some historical and cultural contexts rather than others, and so on? This differs from still a third question: How do we explain the origins of a particular war? Most international relations scholars (and particularly those in North America) focus primarily on the second question, explaining variations in war and peace. They leave the question of why war occurs at all to philosophers and biologists and leave the question of why a particular war occurs to historians.

Although **anarchy** may provide one persuasive answer to the question of the permissive causes of war, it is generally treated as a structural constant and consequently it cannot account for variations in war and peace.

5.1 The Levels-of-Analysis Framework

Waltz (1959) classified the causes of war in terms of their origins in the individual, the nation-state, and the international system ⇒ levels-of-analysis framework as an organizing device for the study of war.

In this sense the systemic level of analysis refers to explanations of patterns and outcomes in the international system; the dyadic level refers to explanations of the strategic interactions between two states; the national level refers to explanations of state foreign policy behavior; the organizational level refers to explanations of the behavior of organizations; and the individual level refers to explanations of the preferences, beliefs, or choices of individuals.

We cannot assume that correlations or causal connections at one level of analysis are necessarily valid at another level. It is conceivable, for example, that concentrations of power may promote peace at the dyadic level but war at the system level.

5.2 Systemic-Level Theories

The realist tradition has dominated the study of war since Thucydides and includes Machiavellians, Hobbesians, classical balance of power theorists, Waltzian neorealists, and hegemonic transition theorists. Although different realist theories often generate conflicting predictions, they share a core of common assumptions: the key actors in world politics are sovereign states that act rationally to advance their security, power, and wealth in a conflictual international system that lacks a legitimate governmental authority to regulate conflicts or enforce agreements.

- they use Prisoner's Dilemma and stag-hunt models
- The core proposition of realist theory is that the distribution of power, throughout the system or within a dyad, is the primary factor shaping international outcomes.

We should treat realism as a paradigm rather than as a theory, and focus instead on specific theories that generate more determinant, testable propositions.

5.2.1 Hegemonic Theory or Power Transition Theory

Hegemonic theory is a structural theory that incorporates power transition theory and hegemonic stability theory and that **downplays the importance of anarchy**.

Hegemons commonly arise and use their strength to create a set of political and economic structures and norms of behavior that enhance the stability of the system while advancing their own security. Differential rates of growth, the costs of imperial overextension, and the development of vested domestic interests lead to the rise and fall of hegemons, and the probability of a major war is greatest at the point when the declining leader is being overtaken by the rising challenger.

Power transition theorists disagree somewhat on the precise identity of hegemonic wars and the particular causal dynamics from which they arise.

5.2.2 Balance of Power Theory

Balance of power theory is more concerned with explaining national strategies, the formation of blocking coalitions, the avoidance of hegemony, and the stability of the system than the origins of wars, which are underdetermined.

There is a major debate, however, between classical realists, who argue that stability is further supported by the presence of a multipolar distribution of power and a "flexible" alliance system (Morgenthau 1967, Gulick 1955), and neorealists, who argue that bipolarity is more stable than multipolarity (Waltz 1979, Mearsheimer 1990).

Balance of power theory and power transition theory appear to be diametrically opposed; the former argues that hegemony never occurs and that concentrations of power are destabilizing, and the latter argues the opposite.

5.2.3 Realism and Liberalism

The relationship between economic interdependence and war is an old question that has attracted new attention in the past few years.

Liberal economic theory of war: Montesquieu [1977 (1748)] stated that "peace is the natural effect of trade," and liberal economic theorists since Smith [1937 (1776)] and Ricardo [1977 (1817)] have argued that capitalist economic systems and the free exchange of goods in an international market economy are the best guarantors of peace.

Realist: they often argue that the effect of trade on war is small relative to that of military and diplomatic considerations. They also question the liberal assumption that trade is always more efficient than military coercion in expanding markets and investment opportunities and in promoting state wealth.

Whether the incentives for the gains from trade dominate the incentives for coercion or protection based on economic asymmetries, and whether the latter escalate to trade wars and militarized conflicts, are empirical questions that analysts have only recently begun to analyze systematically.

Historical and empirical evidence of trade between enemies

Although liberals and realists disagree on the effects of trade on war, **they appear to agree that trade and other forms of economic interchange between societies will cease or be drastically reduced once states are at war with each other.** Contrary to both liberal and realist expectations, however, **there are numerous historical cases of trade between enemies** during wartime, and a preliminary quantitative study suggests that war frequently

does little to depress the volume of trade between adversaries (Barbieri & Levy 1997).

Need to incorporate domestic variables into their hypotheses

States often hesitate to terminate trade with the enemy for fear that they will lose that trade to a third party, who may be a greater economic or military rival.

These omissions have led all but the most committed neorealists to conclude that **systemic-level theories are theoretically incomplete and empirically inadequate**, in that **they leave too much of the variation in the outbreak and expansion of war unexplained.**

5.3 Social-Level Theories

Although interest in Marxist-Leninist theories has waned, there has been a tremendous growth of research on the relationships between regime type, particularly democratic regimes, and war (analyzed by Ray in this volume). Scholars have also devoted attention to the "diversionary" use of force for domestic political purposes, to the impact of ethnonationalism on international conflict, and to other domestic sources of international conflict.

"rally around the flag" effect (Mueller 1973).

This is the age-old "scapegoat hypothesis" or "diversionary theory of war" (Levy 1989a).

As Bodin argued, "the best way of preserving a state, and guaranteeing it against sedition, rebellion, and civil war is to...find an enemy against whom [the subjects] can make common cause" (quoted in Levy 1989a, p. 259).

research on the scapegoat hypothesis

The absence of significant findings regarding the relationship between internal and external conflict contrasts sharply with evidence of external scapegoating from historical and journalistic accounts and from a growing body of case-study evidence.

Most of these studies have focused on democratic regimes, partly because of the ease of measuring elite support levels but also because of the assumption that the greater political accountability of leaders in democratic states makes them more likely than authoritarian leaders to engage in external scapegoating.

These models help to explain "gambling for resurrection" through risky foreign policies by poor leaders who expect to be removed by their constituents (Downs & Rocke 1995).

This raises the question of how external actors perceive and respond to diversionary actions.

Marxist-Leninist models of imperialism, like models of scapegoating, implicitly assume that external expansion and the use of force serve the interests of the ruling class or elite but not those of society as a whole.

If the costs of aggressive foreign policies are too high—and we have enough examples of "imperial overstretch" to suggest that they sometimes are—it is not clear how elites maintain their power. As Snyder (1991) argued, groups concentrated enough to benefit from overexpansion are too narrow to control state policy, while those broad enough to control policy are too diffuse to reap benefits from overexpansionist policies.

For Snyder, this rationalist model of logrolling is not sufficient to explain overexpansion or the stability of the ruling coalition.

5.4 Individual-Level Theories

decision-making is characterized by “bounded rationality” **Assumptions:**

(a) that external and internal structures and social forces are not translated directly into foreign policy choices;

(b) that key decision-makers vary in their definitions of state interests, assessments of threats to those interests, and/or beliefs as to the optimum strategies to achieve those interests; and

(c) that differences in the content of actors' belief systems, in the psychological processes through which they acquire information and make judgments and decisions, and in their personalities and emotional states are important intervening variables in explaining observed variation in state behaviors with respect to issues of war and peace.

Prospect Theory one of the most recent attempts to apply a social-psychological model to international relations (Kahneman & Tversky (1979)).

Prospect theory assumes that people evaluate outcomes in terms of deviations from a reference point or aspiration level rather than in terms of net-asset levels.

This asymmetry of behavior with respect to gains and losses means that the way people frame their reference point in any given choice problem is critical.

5.5 General Trends

- shift away from the systemic level: dissatisfaction with the failure of structural systemic models to explain enough of the variance in war and peace. This shift has led to rising interest in both dyadic-level behavior and societal-level explanatory variables.
- Whatever the relationship between concentrations of military and economic capabilities at the systemic level, there is substantial evidence that at the dyadic level an equality of capabilities is significantly more likely to lead to war.
- In the past decade most international relations theorists have moved beyond their earlier preoccupation with explanations at a single level of analysis and debates about which level provides the most powerful explanations. They now give much more attention to interaction effects among variables at different levels in the processes leading to war

6 One World Rival Theories

Cranmer and Desmarais (2017)

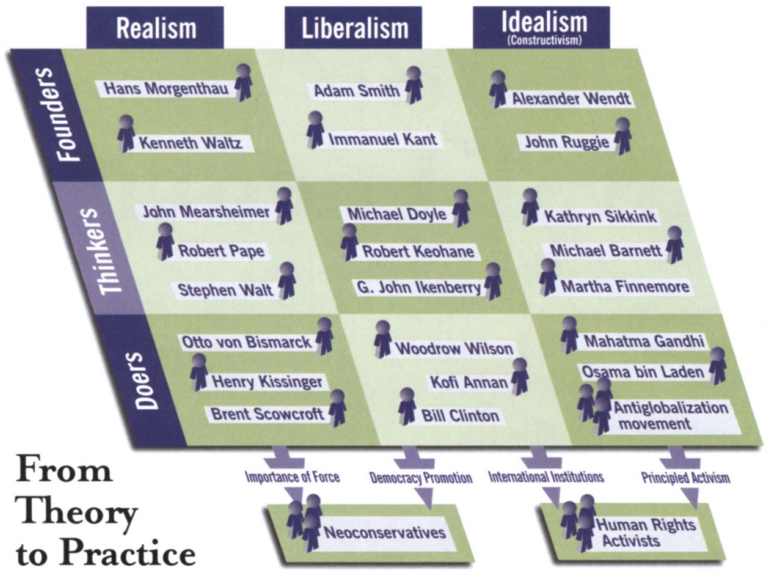


Figura 3

Realism instills a pragmatic appreciation of the role of power but also warns that states will suffer if they overreach. Liberalism highlights the cooperative potential of mature democracies, especially when working together through effective institutions, but it also notes democracies' tendency to crusade against tyrannies and the propensity of emerging democracies to collapse into violent ethnic turmoil.

Idealism stresses that a consensus on values must underpin any stable political order, yet it also recognizes that forging such a consensus often requires an ideological struggle with the potential for conflict.

It is harder for the normally state-centric realists to explain why the world's only superpower announced a war against al Qaeda, a nonstate terrorist organization. How can realist theory account for the importance of powerful and violent individuals in a world of states? Realists point out that the

Post-9/11 developments seem to undercut one of realism's core concepts: the balance of power.

When Germany unified in the late 19th century and became Europe's leading military and industrial power, Russia and France (and later, Britain) soon aligned to counter its power. Yet no combination of states or other powers can challenge the United States militarily, and no balancing coalition is imminent.

6.1 The Divided House of Liberalism

For its part, the Bush administration highlights democracy promotion while largely turning its back on the international institutions that most liberal theorists champion.

The belief that democracies never fight wars against each other is the closest thing we have to an iron law in social science.

Shortly before September 11, political scientist G. John Ikenberry studied attempts to establish international order by the victors of hegemonic struggles in 1815, 1919, 1945, and 1989. He argued that even the most powerful victor needed to gain the willing cooperation of the vanquished and other weak states by offering a mutually attractive bargain, codified in an international constitutional order.

The Leading Brands

Theories:	Realism	Liberalism	Idealism (Constructivism)
Core Beliefs	Self-interested states compete for power and security	Spread of democracy, global economic ties, and international organizations will strengthen peace	International politics is shaped by persuasive ideas, collective values, culture, and social identities
Key Actors in International Relations	States, which behave similarly regardless of their type of government	States, international institutions, and commercial interests	Promoters of new ideas, transnational activist networks, and nongovernmental organizations
Main Instruments	Military power and state diplomacy	International institutions and global commerce	Ideas and values
Theory's Intellectual Blind Spots	Doesn't account for progress and change in international relations or understanding that legitimacy can be a source of military power	Fails to understand that democratic regimes survive only if they safeguard military power and security; some liberals forget that transitions to democracy are sometimes violent	Does not explain which power structures and social conditions allow for changes in values
What the Theory Explains About the Post-9/11 World	Why the United States responded aggressively to terrorist attacks; the inability of international institutions to restrain military superiority	Why spreading democracy has become such an integral part of current U.S. international security strategy	The increasing role of polemics about values; the importance of transnational political networks (whether terrorists or human rights advocates)
What the Theory Fails to Explain About the Post-9/11 World	The failure of smaller powers to militarily balance the United States; the importance of non-state actors such as al Qaeda; the intense U.S. focus on democratization	Why the United States has failed to work with other democracies through international organizations	Why human rights abuses continue, despite intense activism for humanitarian norms and efforts for international justice

Figura 4

6.2 Idealism

Idealism: the belief that foreign policy is and should be guided by ethical and legal standards.

Constructivism is a new version of idealism: holds that social reality is created through debate about values, often echoes the themes that human rights and international justice activists sound.

Perhaps most important, Europe's increasingly legalistic approach to international relations, reflected in the process of forming the European Union out of a collection of sovereign states, provides fertile soil for idealist and constructivist conceptions of international politics.

Whereas realists dwell on the balance of power and liberals on the power of international trade and democracy, constructivists believe that debates about ideas are the fundamental building blocks of international life. Individuals and groups become powerful if they can convince others to adopt their ideas.

Realists failed to predict the end of the Cold War, for example. Even after it happened, they tended to assume that the new system would become multipolar.

Likewise, the liberal theory of democratic peace is stronger on what happens after states become democratic than in predicting the timing of democratic transitions, let alone prescribing how to make transitions happen peacefully.

Constructivists are good at describing changes in norms and ideas, but they are weak on the material and institutional circumstances necessary to support the emergence of consensus about new values and ideas.

With such uncertain guidance from the theoretical realm, it is no wonder that policymakers, activists, and public commentators fall prey to simplistic or wishful thinking about how to effect change.

7 Why "isms" Are Evil David Lake

Cranmer and Desmarais, 2017

7.1 Central Argument and Purpose

Lake's essay is a critique of how international studies is organized intellectually and professionally. His central claim is not that theoretical diversity is undesirable, but that scholars have turned theoretical traditions and epistemological preferences into academic "sects." Instead of using theories as limited tools for understanding specific problems, researchers often treat broad traditions such as realism, liberalism, constructivism, Marxism, neoliberal institutionalism, feminism, or the English School as competing intellectual religions. Each group tends to defend its own assumptions, produce research that confirms those assumptions, and debate rival traditions at the level of first principles. In Lake's view, this sectarian organization generates less understanding rather than more. It also distracts scholars from their fundamental social responsibility: improving knowledge of world politics and, where possible, identifying ways to promote more humane outcomes.

The problem is especially serious because the discipline does not possess a single, universal and empirically powerful theory of international politics. World politics is too complex, and existing knowledge is too incomplete, for one general framework to explain everything. Lake therefore urges intellectual humility. Scholars should accept that most theories are partial and contingent, specify the conditions under which they apply, and concentrate on mid-level explanations of concrete phenomena. He favors "analytic eclecticism": researchers should be willing to draw on different assumptions and theories when different problems require different tools. At the epistemological level, he makes a parallel argument. The divide between nomological and narrative forms of explanation is real and enduring, but neither approach is universally superior. Both can produce valid knowledge, and the relevant question is which approach is most illuminating for a particular research problem.

7.2 Theory: How Research Traditions Become Academic Sects

Each research tradition contains a set of core assumptions concerning the relevant actors in world politics, their interests, the processes through which they make decisions, and the nature of political interaction.

International politics is an exceptionally complicated social system, so it is unsurprising that different approaches illuminate different parts of it. The discipline's weakness lies not in pluralism itself but in the professional practices that transform pluralism into sectarianism.

7.3 The first pathology: reifying research traditions

The first pathology is the reification of research traditions. Scholars routinely organize literature reviews, courses, graduate seminars, handbooks, and disciplinary histories around familiar "isms." This has practical advantages because it provides a convenient map of a large literature, but it also creates artificial boundaries. Complex scholarship is reduced to a few recognizable schools,

subtle differences within traditions disappear, and authors are classified according to labels they may not accept themselves. In the process, qualifications and subtleties are often lost. Scholars may see their own work as eclectic and nuanced while categorizing opponents as "realists," "constructivists," or "liberals." As a result, intellectual identities are partly imposed by others. The discipline collectively produces the very categories that then appear to be natural and independent objects.

7.4 The second pathology: reification of canonical works and rewarding extremism

Younger scholars learn that professional recognition may come from taking a distinctive sectarian position. New "isms" and specialized sections of professional become vehicles for status and intellectual entrepreneurship.

7.5 The third pathology: confusing traditions with theories

The third pathology is the tendency to mistake a research tradition for a complete theory.

Several distinct theories can coexist inside a single tradition—for example, offensive realism, defensive realism, and neoclassical realism. They share some core premises but differ in auxiliary assumptions.

Because traditions are often underspecified, they cannot be meaningfully "tested" as wholes. Yet scholars frequently stage empirical contests between traditions as if each generated clear predictions, producing debates in which each side can interpret evidence as confirmation.

7.6 The fourth pathology: selective empirical focus

The fourth pathology is empirical selectivity. Researchers tend to study the **topics, periods, and cases in which their preferred tradition performs well**.

This pattern can emerge naturally because scholars test theories where they initially expect them to work, while journals and publishers also favor positive findings.

The cumulative consequence is self-confirmation. Each tradition studies its strongest domain, finds supportive evidence, and then treats that evidence as proof of general explanatory power.

7.7 The fifth pathology: the search for intellectual hegemony

The fifth pathology is the aspiration of each research tradition to become the dominant scientific paradigm. Professional incentives reinforce this competition. If a tradition becomes dominant, its leading scholars gain status, influence, and control over disciplinary agendas. Because every group fears losing ground to its rivals, competition for hegemony resembles an arms race: even scholars who would prefer cooperation feel pressure to defend and expand their approach. The collective result is worse for everyone. Rather than acknowledging the limited scope of existing theories, research communities expend enormous energy debating assumptions. Comparable theoriesf are not applied to the same phenomena.

7.8 Lake's Alternative: Problems, Partial Theories, and a Common Lexicon

Lake's preferred alternative is to reorganize scholarship and academic life around substantive problems rather than around intellectual sects. The guiding question would then be "What do we

know about this problem?" rather than "What are the core assumptions of this school?" Such an organization would encourage scholars to compare explanations on the basis of their contribution to understanding a phenomenon instead of their loyalty to a tradition.

A central part of this alternative is what Lake calls an "embrace of partiality." His metaphor is the familiar image of several people touching different parts of an elephant: each theory may capture one part accurately, while no single theory describes the entire animal.

7.9 Interests, interactions, and institutions

Analytic eclecticism creates a possible communication problem: if scholars abandon fixed traditions, the field could become a "tower of Babel" in which theories are too different to compare. Lake therefore proposes a common lexicon built around three broad concepts: interests, interactions, and institutions. Any complete theory of politics must specify who the relevant actors are, what they want, how they interact, and the institutional environment in which interaction occurs.

This lexicon is deliberately neutral among traditions so that ir can still be translated into the same basic questions about actors, interests, interactions, and institutions.

7.10 Epistemology: The Enduring Divide

Lake then turns from theory to epistemology. He identifies a deep divide between nomological and narrative forms of explanation. he does not believe that one epistemology will or should defeat the other. The discipline should therefore accept epistemological diversity.

7.11 The nomological approach

The nomological approach seeks generalizable explanations based on covering laws or theoretically specified relationships. It typically uses the hypothetical-deductive method: researchers derive falsifiable propositions of the form "if X, then Y" and test them using designs that approximate controlled experiments. True experiments offer the strongest internal validity, followed by quasi-experiments and then correlational studies such as regression analysis. External validity therefore rests on clearly specified scope and boundary conditions.

7.12 The narrative approach

The narrative protocol begins with a descriptive order that links events. It then constructs an interpretation of the historical facts.

Abduction.

The objective is to produce a **convincing and plausible account** of events.

Narrative explanations are often richer and more holistic than nomological models.

Their weakness is that the criteria for judging causal adequacy are more subjective.

7.13 Epistemological Sectarianism and Lake's Recommendations

The same pathologies that affect theory also affect epistemology.

Epistemological gatekeepers can influence hiring, resource allocation, publication, and access to professional networks, encouraging scholars to cluster with others who share the same standards

of explanation. Lake sees no objective basis for declaring one epistemology universally superior. Scholars may simply find one form of explanation more intuitively satisfying than another, much as some people find beauty in mathematics and others in poetry.

7.14 Conclusion

Lake's alternative is more problem-centered.

The ultimate measure of success should be whether scholarship improves our understanding of world politics and contributes, where possible, to social progress.

8 Challenges to the Liberal Order: Summary

David A. Lake, Lisa L. Martin, and Thomas Risse (2021)

8.1 Introduction and Central Argument

The Liberal International Order (LIO) is under pressure from several directions at once. The authors emphasize that the postwar order has survived serious crises before, so its collapse should not be assumed.

The LIO has structured relations among the capitalist, democratic, and industrialized states since the late 1940s and has had wider global effects. It is associated with unprecedented cooperation among North America, Western Europe, and Japan, the emergence of a pluralistic security community, expansion of trade and capital mobility, high economic growth, the diffusion of democracy, and the development of an international human-rights regime.

8.2 Order

An order consists of patterned or structured relations. The LIO is clearly rule-governed and sustained by coordinated action by both state and nonstate actors.

8.3 International and the Westphalian Order

The "international" component of the LIO has to be understood in relation to the Westphalian order. In the authors' usage, Westphalia is not literally a system created in 1648 but a later order centered on sovereign nation-states, sovereign equality, recognition by other states, and noninterference in domestic affairs. The LIO and the Westphalian order partly overlap and have coevolved since 1945. They share principles such as sovereign equality, peaceful settlement of disputes, self-determination, and nonintervention. At the same time, the LIO goes beyond Westphalia through principles such as human rights and forms of legitimate collective intrusion into domestic affairs.

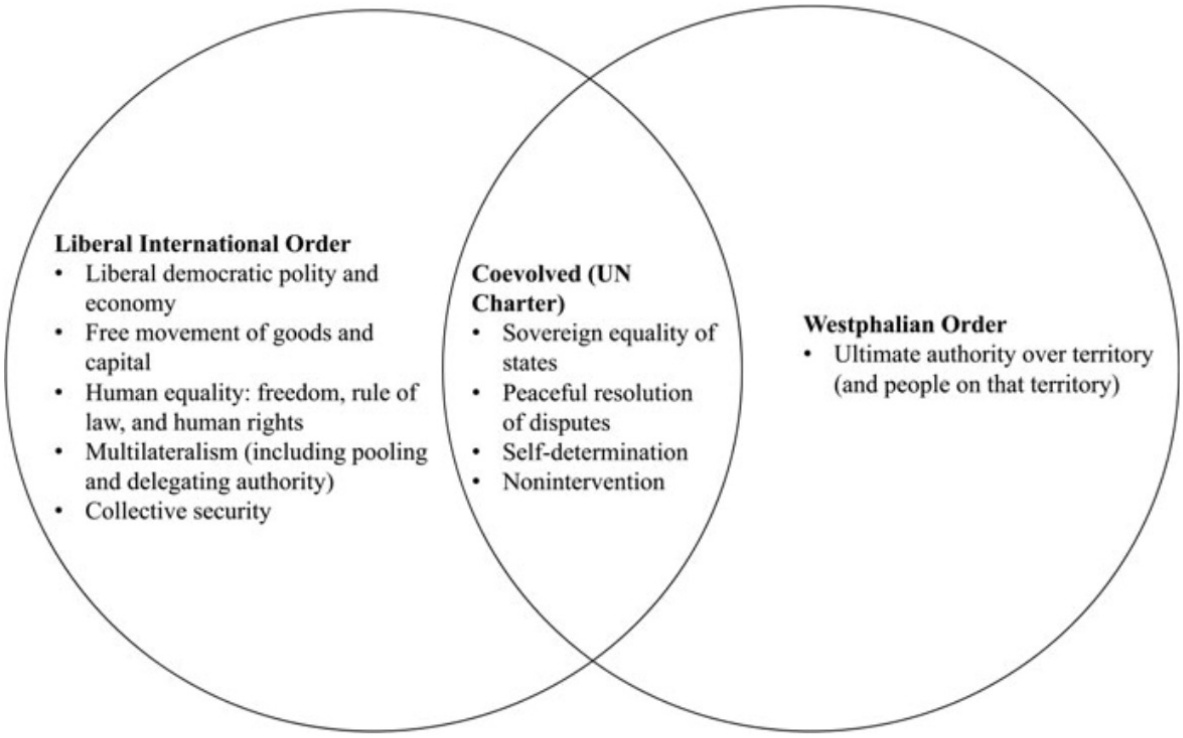


FIGURE 1. *The LIO and the Westphalian order*

Figura 5

8.4 Liberal: Political Liberalism

At its philosophical core, liberalism rests on universal human equality, freedom, and individual and collective self-determination. Political liberalism therefore implies the rule of law, representative government, political participation, and protection of individual rights.

Institutions such as the International Criminal Court and doctrines such as the Responsibility to Protect illustrate how the LIO can authorize constraints on domestic sovereignty in the name of universal rights.

8.5 Economic Liberalism and Embedded Liberalism

A classical version favors market capitalism, free trade, international capital mobility, and equal treatment of foreign investment.

A second, historically important version is embedded liberalism. The postwar architects of the Bretton Woods system combined trade liberalization with domestic welfare states.

The distinction is important because economic liberalism does not automatically contradict Westphalian sovereignty.

The LIO broadly liberalized goods, services, and capital but never generally established free movement of labor outside the EU.

8.6 Liberal Internationalism

The institutional dimension of the LIO is based on principled multilateralism. Multilateralism means more than coordination among several states: it means coordination according to generalized rules that apply across cases rather than ad hoc bargaining based solely on particular interests. The GATT,WTO and UN Charter exemplify this logic. Liberal internationalism also includes peaceful dispute resolution, the ambition to provide global public goods, security communities such as NATO, and multilateral arms-control and nonproliferation regimes.

Tensions with Westphalia:

1. Authority is delegated supranational bodies
2. Majority voting
3. Dispute-settlement mechanisms
4. International courts.

8.7 Universalism and Selective Participation

The LIO contains a paradox. Because liberalism begins from universal equality, the order is in principle open to all states. Yet states can join important parts of the LIO without being liberal democracies.

The LIO is therefore best understood as an evolving order whose components vary in reach rather than as a single uniform system imposed everywhere by the United States.

8.8 Challenges from Within the Liberal Core

The most striking contemporary threats come not only from geopolitical rivals but also from the internal workings of liberalism itself. The authors identify several mechanisms through which the LIO generates opposition within its own core members.

1. Economic liberalism creates winners and losers. Trade openness, technological change, global production chains, and the financial crisis of 2008–2010 have produced geographically concentrated losses and contributed to rising inequality.
2. Political openness can be used against liberalism. Freedom of expression and the open architecture of the internet allow misinformation, foreign influence, and strategies of "truth subversion" to circulate widely.
3. Free-trade policies and supranational governance were sometimes insulated from popular pressure in order to prevent protectionism and secure long-term cooperation. Over time, however, this technocratic insulation excluded some constituencies and created resentment. International institutions appeared less responsive to citizens.
4. liberal universalism collides with national identity. Who belongs to the national community? Migration is a problem

8.9 Nationalist Populism and Political Realignment

These pressures converge in movements combining nationalism, populism, and authoritarianism. Nationalism prioritizes the interests and identity of a particular state; populism pits a supposedly

homogeneous "people" against elites and pluralist institutions; authoritarianism rejects liberal constraints such as independent courts, a free press, and fair electoral competition.

8.10 External Challengers

- Climate change
- Distributional conflicts due to Climate change
- China: Its extraordinary economic growth was enabled by participation in the open international economy, yet China remains authoritarian and strongly defends sovereignty and noninterference.

8.11 The Erosion of Multilateral Institutions

Internal and external challenges converge most directly in attacks on multilateralism. Multilateral institutions have experienced crises before, including the collapse of the Bretton Woods monetary system and the US decision to invade Iraq without broad UN support. What appears different in the contemporary period is the breadth of skepticism and the willingness of major states to weaken institutions without a clear systemic necessity.

1. WTO crisis: Even before the recent crisis it struggled to negotiate large new trade agreements. The United States combined protectionist tariffs with a strategy of blocking appointments to the WTO Appellate Body, impairing enforcement.
2. Refugee crisis: The refugee regime illustrates a broader erosion of multilateral commitments. The principle of nonrefoulement and the 1951 Refugee Convention created legal obligations toward asylum seekers, yet receiving states have increasingly adopted restrictive or deterrent policies.

8.12 Sources of Resilience

1. the order has produced substantial benefits: reduced conflict among core members, economic growth, lower global poverty, and extensive international cooperation.
2. LIO has generated vested interests: Firms have built global investments and supply chains that depend on open trade and predictable international rules. The same interdependence that creates vulnerability can also reinforce support for openness.
3. the LIO institutions can outlast the circumstances that produced them and act as shock absorbers during crises.
4. **Legitimacy**: After decades of operation, many rules of multilateral cooperation have acquired a sense of normality and rightfulness. Practices that once required active justification can become taken for granted as normal components of international life.

   Accumulated normative capital

   Political baseline

8.13 Four Analytic Blind Spots in IR Scholarship

1. **Exclusion**, stigma, and the threat of losing membership help enforce order. Exclusion is not merely a defect at the margins of the LIO.
2. **Orders Are Not Neutral:** distributional consequences and the fact that rules are written by particular actors for particular purposes. Cooperation can be Pareto-improving while still distributing gains unequally.
3. **Institutions Depend on Social Foundations:** Institutions survive because social groups invest political resources in creating and defending them. Institutional insulation may sometimes be necessary to protect long-term cooperation from short-term pressures.
4. **Domestic Politics Can Challenge the Order Itself:** IR scholarship paid little attention to the possibility that parties, protest movements, territorial cleavages, and mass political realignments inside core states could attack the international order itself.

8.14 USA and the Future of LIO

Question about American leadership.

- The LIO could survive because existing institutions and old and new stakeholders defend it.
- more traditional Westphalian order centered on sovereignty and noninterference.
- It could be transformed into a hybrid order that preserves economic openness and principled multilateralism while altering commitments to democracy, human rights, and international legal authority.

Part II

Text as Data

*** Cranmer and Desmarais (2017, Introduction)

- Cranmer and Desmarais (2017, Chapter 1)
- Cranmer and Desmarais (2017, Chapter 2)

9 Semantic Role Labeling

9.1 Selectorate Theory

The selectorate theory represents one version of the strategic perspective.

In selectorate theory, leaders build a coalition of supporters among the selectorate. The selectorate (S) consists of those who have at least a nominal say in choosing leaders and are eligible to become members of a winning coalition. The winning coalition (W) is the subset of the selectorate without whose support an incumbent cannot be sustained in office.

Leaders attempt to retain the loyalty of their supporters by giving them more benefits than any domestic political opponent can credibly promise to deliver. Rewards come in two varieties:

(1) private goods:

Private goods are rewards that benefit only those who get them—that is, members of the leader's essential coalition of supporters.

Examples might include privileged access to government contracts, exploitation of a black market, or protection against prosecution.

(2) public goods.

Public goods are government policies and programs that all people benefit from whether they are in the leader's inner circle or not.

Examples of public goods include national defense, free speech and free assembly, public parks, equal protection under the law, and free access to education.

The selectorate theory's five rules of governance are as follows:

1. Depend on as few key people to keep you in power as possible.
2. Draw that small group of essential coalition members from as large a pool of people as possible.
3. Tax people as much as possible, subject to the constraints that they continue to work and pay taxes rather than take siestas, and that they are not made so miserable that they decide it is worthwhile to risk revolting rather than continue to live with the existing political system.
4. Reward your essential backers just enough so they stick with you rather than shopping around for a new leader who might do more for them.

5. Don't spend resources on benefiting the general population when those resources are needed to keep the loyalty of the members of your essential coalition.

When domestic institutions constrain a leader to require a broad base of support private rewards are an inefficient way to retain power (de Tocqueville 2000; Lake and Baum 2001; Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Bueno de Mesquita and Smith 2011). Democratic leaders would have to spread these rewards across so many people that each would receive too little for the benefits to influence their loyalty to the incumbent.

When political institutions compel a leader to depend on many supporters so that a bundle of public goods is the reward for retaining the incumbent, **the institutions of governance induce weak loyalty to the incumbent**.

Conversely, when a leader needs backing only from a few people to stay in power, the few are expected to be loyal both because they are well rewarded with private benefits and because they face a high risk of losing those privileges if a challenger topples the incumbent regime.

Historically, we have spoken of categorical types of regimes, like democracies or autocracies. In practice, no two governments are alike. All political systems have two institutional characteristics that describe how they retain and select their leaders.

When W/S is small, as in a rigged election autocracy, then there is a **strong loyalty norm** that makes it easy for leaders to survive in power and exert great discretion over revenue as explained next.

Examples: Egypt vs HCina and Syria vs Nigeria For example, China and Egypt both had winning coalitions with a size that was close to 0 percent of the adult population, yet Egypt back then had a larger real selectorate than China relative to their adult populations. This means that both regimes, as we will see, were heavily oriented toward private goods but that leaders had more discretion over revenue in Egypt than in China. All else being equal, then, Egypt's then leader Hosni Mubarak had a better chance of remaining in power against an ordinary political challenge than did China's then incumbent president Hu Jintao.

Syria and Nigeria differ markedly. Nigeria has a smaller selectorate than Syria but depends on a much larger winning coalition. This means that the loyalty norm is stronger in Syria than in Nigeria. That makes the preparedness of the winning coalition's members to take extraordinary actions on behalf of the incumbent regime more robust in Syria than in Nigeria.

Examples: Putin Putin needed support from only half the members of parliament to get their legislative program through the Duma and, in a two-party race, each candidate needed only half the voters to support him to be elected, making the maximum minimal winning coalition in Russia 25 percent [0.5 (voters per seat) x 0.5 (number of seats)]. With more than two parties (and there were seven parties contesting the 2011 Duma election), the actual minimal winning coalition was smaller.

9.2 Public and Private Goods: Who Gets Rewarded as W and S Change?

W = Winning Coalition, it is the subset of the selectorate without whose support an incumbent cannot be sustained in office.

R = Total revenues

p = price of public goods

g = mix of public goods

z = each coalition member's private goods benefits

$$z = (R - p * g)/W$$

The odds of being in a successor coalition are the ratio W/S, which in this case is 100/1,000,000, or 1/10,000.

The expected value of the prospective defector's share of the private goods to be dispensed by the successor regime is only 1000.

$$\frac{total\ revenues}{number\ of\ winning\ coalition} * probability\ of\ belonging\ to\ the\ coalition =$$

$$\frac{R}{W} * \frac{W}{S} = \frac{1,000,000,000}{100} * \frac{100}{1,000,000} = 1000$$

The incumbent can keep the difference between the 10 million per supporter that could be distributed, and the something above 1,000 per supporter that needs to be distributed.

It is easy to see that as long as the incumbent beats that expectation and provides public policies that are not much worse than those proposed by the challenger, the would-be defector can be kept happy and loyal.

9.2.1 Conclusions

1. **the greatest incumbency advantage in using private goods to satisfy constituents belongs to the leaders of political systems that have small winning coalitions and large selectorates.**
2. **Supporters in a large-coalition public-goods-oriented setting receive the benefits of public goods even if their leader is replaced by a challenger, such as after an election. This means that they can support a challenger with little consequence since they are getting few private gains in any event.**

9.2.2 Leader Survival

Autocracy and democracy are fundamentally different in their consequences even though all leaders are assumed to want the same thing (to keep their jobs and have discretion over as many resources as possible). Democratic politics in selectorate theory is a competition in competence to produce public goods; autocratic politics centers on the purchase of the loyalty of key supporters through bribery, corruption, and rent seeking.

9.2.3 Conclusion

The selectorate theory logically implies several basic principles of politics that are applied repeatedly throughout this book. The most important of these principles are as follows:

1. Regimes with large winning coalitions focus on effective policies, including foreign policies. When leaders' policies do poorly, they either switch them or pour more resources into trying to make them succeed.

2. Regimes with small winning coalitions tolerate failed domestic and foreign policies better than do regimes with large coalitions because in small-coalition settings loyalty to a leader depends more on receiving private rewards than public benefits. As a consequence, leaders mostly continue on their policy course even when their policies are failing. They do not change course as quickly as large-coalition leaders, and they do not put extra resources into trying to make the policies, including foreign security and trade policies, succeed under most circumstances.

3. The likelihood that a leader survives in office despite failed policies increases as W/S decreases (so that the polity becomes more autocratic) and decreases as W/S increases (so that the polity becomes more democratic).

4. As W/S increases, leaders must spend more revenue to maintain loyalty among their coalition members and, as a result, these leaders have proportionately fewer revenue sources at their discretionary use than do those who depend on a small coalition drawn from a large selectorate.

5. Corruption and kleptocracy (governing by theft) increase in prominence as W gets smaller, especially when S also gets larger.

6. The foreign policies of small-coalition leaders are more heavily driven by the pursuit of opportunities for enrichment through territorial conquest, tribute, and the like rather than the pursuit of policy compliance from foreign rivals.

7. The foreign policies of large-coalition leaders are more heavily driven by the pursuit of policy compliance by foreign governments than by the pursuit of enrichment.

8. When leaders can change political arrangements, they prefer to decrease the size of their coalition and increase the size of the selectorate.

9. When coalition members can change institutions (e.g., through coups), they always prefer to increase the ratio W/S and may, depending on circumstances, prefer to do so by increasing W more quickly than S or decreasing W more slowly than S.

10. When people who are not in the coalition have the opportunity to change institutions of government (e.g., through revolution or civil war), they always prefer to increase W and to increase W/S.

Bibliography

Articles

Cranmer, S. J., & Desmarais, B. A. (2017). What Can We Learn from Predictive Modeling? *Political Analysis*, *25*(2), 145–166. https://doi.org/10.1017/pan.2017.3